

High-Protein Pasta with Peas

This one-pot pasta with peas is packed with plant-based protein and a healthy dose of fiber. The chickpea pasta is cooked with vibrant green peas and tossed with fragrant basil and a rich pesto sauce for fresh flavor in every bite. Nutty toasted pine nuts provide the perfect crunch, adding depth and texture.

By **Craig Ruff** | Updated on August 24, 2025

✓ Reviewed by Dietitian **Emily Lachtrupp, M.S., RD**

Active Time: 40 mins

Total Time: 40 mins

Servings: 6

Nutrition Profile:

No Added Sugar Gut Healthy Mediterranean Diet Sesame-Free Weight Loss Diabetes-Friendly Healthy Pregnancy Soy-Free High-Fiber Heart-Healthy Vegetarian High-Protein Egg-Free Gluten-Free

Ingredients

- ⅓ cup unsalted pine nuts
- 2 tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil
- 2 medium shallots, finely chopped (about ⅔ cup)
- 4 large cloves garlic, finely chopped (about 2 tablespoons)
- ½ teaspoon kosher salt
- ½ teaspoon cracked black pepper
- 12 ounces chickpea pasta
- 4 cups water
- 1 (10-ounce) package frozen green peas
- ⅔ cup coarsely chopped fresh basil
- ¼ cup finely grated Parmesan cheese, plus more for garnish
- 3 tablespoons refrigerated basil pesto
- 1 teaspoon grated lemon zest
- 2 tablespoons lemon juice

Directions

Step 1

Combine $\frac{1}{3}$ cup pine nuts and 2 tablespoons oil in a large Dutch oven; cook over medium heat, stirring often, until the pine nuts are toasted and brown, 5 to 6 minutes. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the toasted pine nuts to a small bowl, reserving the oil in the pot.

Step 2

Add chopped shallots, chopped garlic, $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon salt and $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon pepper to the reserved oil in the Dutch oven. Cook over medium-low heat, stirring often, until softened, about 2 minutes. Stir in 12 ounces pasta and 4 cups water; bring to a boil over high heat, stirring occasionally. Reduce to a lively simmer; cover and cook, stirring occasionally, until the pasta is almost al dente, about 6 minutes (some liquid will remain).

Step 3

Stir 10 ounces frozen peas into the pasta mixture; cook, uncovered, over medium-low heat, stirring often, until the peas are heated through and the pasta is al dente, about 2 minutes. Remove from heat; stir in $\frac{3}{4}$ cup basil, $\frac{1}{4}$ cup Parmesan, 3 tablespoons pesto, 1 teaspoon lemon zest and 2 tablespoons lemon juice. Divide among 6 bowls and sprinkle with the reserved toasted pine nuts. Garnish with additional Parmesan, if desired.

Frequently Asked Questions

What other vegetables can I use?

We recommend sticking with veggies that cook quickly. Snap peas, snow peas, asparagus or spinach would all make good additions.

What's the best pesto to use?

Any store-bought pesto will suffice, or you can make your own with our Classic Basil Pesto. We prefer refrigerated pesto over shelf-stable pesto because it tastes brighter. For a flavor twist, try using sun-dried tomato pesto instead.

How can I make this recipe dairy-free?

Use vegan pesto and leave out the Parmesan cheese to make this pasta dairy-free. To mimic the cheesy flavor, you can sprinkle the pasta with nutritional yeast instead.

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Nutrition Facts

Per serving: **Serving Size about 1 $\frac{1}{3}$ cups** 414 calories; total fat 16g; saturated fat 2g; cholesterol 4mg; sodium 275mg; total carbohydrate 55g; dietary fiber 7g; total sugars 6g; protein 15g; vitamin c 9mg; calcium 118mg; iron 4mg; potassium 366mg

Additional reporting by Hilary Meyer and Alex Loh

*Additional reporting by **Hilary Meyer** and **Alex Loh***

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